

Qualified

*Understanding the Elder Qualifications of 1 Timothy 3 and
Titus 1 in Real Church Life*

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Qualified

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Contents

QUALIFIED	1
QUALIFIED	
Introduction: A Portrait, Not a Checklist	2
Introduction: A Portrait, Not a Checklist	
Why the Standard Exists	5
Why the Standard Exists	
Above Reproach	10
Above Reproach	
Husband of One Wife, Managing His Household	15
Husband of One Wife, Managing His Household	
Self-Controlled, Sober-Minded, Respectable	21
Self-Controlled, Sober-Minded, Respectable	
Able to Teach, Not a Lover of Money, Not a Recent Convert	27
Able to Teach, Not a Lover of Money, Not a Recent Convert	

Designing a Meaningful Evaluation		33
Process		
Designing a Meaningful Evaluation Process		
Conclusion: The Standard Is an Act of		39
Love		
Conclusion: The Standard Is an Act of Love		

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UNDERSTANDING THE ELDER QUALIFICATIONS of 1
Timothy 3 and Titus 1 in Real Church Life

Pastors Connection Network

pastorsconnectionnetwork.com

Introduction: A Portrait, Not a Checklist

SOMEONE IN YOUR CONGREGATION is going to be nominated for eldership. Perhaps it is a man you know well and trust deeply. Perhaps it is someone you have concerns about but whose family has been in the church for decades. Perhaps it is a genuinely gifted leader whose personal life you have not looked at closely enough.

In most churches, the process that follows will involve a conversation or two, a vote, a brief congratulation from the pulpit, and a seat at the next board meeting. The biblical qualifications for elders — the long, specific, theologically weighty list in 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1 — will either be consulted as a perfunctory checklist or not consulted at all.

This book is written for the church that wants to do better than that.

The qualifications Paul gives for eldership are not administrative requirements. They are not bureaucratic boxes to be checked before a title is conferred. They are a

That standard is not impossible. But it is demanding. And recovering it is one of the most important acts of pastoral courage a church can undertake.

The saying is trustworthy: If anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a noble task. Therefore an overseer must be above reproach... — 1 Timothy 3:1–2a

We begin with a note that often goes unremarked. Paul says that desiring the office of overseer is to desire a “noble task” — the word is *kalon ergon*, a beautiful work. The eldership is not primarily an honor to be received. It is a work to be done. And the qualifications that follow are not requirements for receiving the honor — they are descriptions of the man who is actually capable of doing the work.

This distinction matters enormously in practice. A church that treats eldership as an honor will fill the office with men who deserve to be honored. A church that treats eldership as a work will fill the office with men who are actually equipped to do it. These are not always the same men.

The chapters that follow examine each of the major qualifications in turn: what the text actually says, what it means in practice, how to apply it in real situations, and what the church loses when it is applied carelessly or not at all. The book closes with a chapter on designing a meaningful

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The sheep need shepherds who are genuinely qualified.
Let's find them.

CHAPTER ONE

Why the Standard Exists

AND WHAT HAPPENS WHEN we lower it

Churches lower the elder qualification standard for all kinds of reasons. Almost none of them are malicious.

Sometimes it happens because of loyalty — a man has given thirty years of faithful, visible service to the congregation, and nominating him for eldership feels like a natural expression of gratitude. Sometimes it happens because of financial pressure — the church's largest giver has always been on the board, and removing him would create an awkward conversation about his continued generosity. Sometimes it happens because of family legacy — the founding family's son has come of age, and it would feel strange not to include him in leadership. And sometimes it happens simply because there is no one obviously better — the pool of candidates is thin, the need is real, and the available man seems like enough.

These are human reasons. They are understandable

THE THEOLOGY BEHIND THE STANDARD

THE BIBLICAL QUALIFICATIONS FOR eldership exist because of a specific theological conviction: that leadership in the body of Christ is always personal before it is positional. The elder does not lead primarily through institutional authority. He leads through his life. His credibility as a shepherd, teacher, and example depends entirely on the quality of his character — on whether the gospel has actually transformed him in the ways the qualifications describe.

This is why Paul's list of elder qualifications in 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1 is so heavily weighted toward character rather than competency. There is almost nothing on the list about organizational skill, strategic thinking, or institutional leadership ability. What is on the list is a portrait of a man whose inner life is genuinely ordered, whose relational life is genuinely healthy, whose public reputation is genuinely positive, and whose doctrinal life is genuinely stable.

That kind of man will be able to shepherd. He will be able to teach. He will be able to set an example. He will be able to stand firm under doctrinal pressure. The competencies of elder ministry — and they are real — flow from this kind of character. They cannot be substituted for it.

WHAT THE CHURCH LOSES WHEN THE STANDARD IS LOWERED

WHEN A CHURCH INSTALLS an elder who does not meet the biblical qualifications, the costs are real and often

But some of the costs take longer to materialize. The elder whose marriage is quietly in crisis will eventually model a marriage that the congregation absorbs. The elder whose relationship with money is disordered will exercise financial oversight in ways that reflect that disorder. The elder who is not genuinely self-controlled will handle conflict in ways that damage rather than heal the congregational culture.

There is also a cultural cost that is perhaps the most serious of all. Every time a church installs an unqualified elder, it communicates something to the congregation about what the office actually requires. It signals that the standard is negotiable — that the right relationships, the right family name, or the right level of financial contribution can qualify a man for an office that Scripture says requires a certain kind of character. Once that signal has been sent, it is very difficult to walk back.

By contrast, every time a church holds the standard firmly — even when it means declining a popular candidate or having a difficult conversation with a longtime member — it communicates that the office means something. That it is not an honor to be conferred but a calling to be discerned. That the men who hold it genuinely carry the weight it implies.

This is a culture worth building. And it begins with a serious engagement with what the qualifications actually require.

THE LOYALTY TRAP IS the most common. A man is nominated not because of his character or his gifts but because of his faithfulness over time. He has been here forever, he has served in every capacity, and the nomination is understood as a form of recognition rather than a genuine assessment of fitness for the office. The problem is that faithfulness in service is not the same thing as qualification for shepherding. The two often coincide, but they are not identical, and treating them as if they are produces elders who were honored rather than called.

The generosity trap is the most dangerous. When a church's significant giver is also on the elder board, an implicit power dynamic is created that compromises the integrity of every decision that touches on finances, and many decisions that don't. The elder whose giving gives him leverage — real or perceived — over the pastor's position or the church's direction is not a shepherd. He is a patron. And the patronage relationship is antithetical to the servant leadership the office requires.

The legacy trap is the subtlest. The founding family's son, the longtime pastor's nephew, the deacon patriarch's grandson — these men sometimes genuinely earn the office through their own character and gifts. But sometimes they are installed because of who they are related to, and the congregation accepts this because it is familiar and because challenging it feels disrespectful. The result is an elder team that includes men whose primary qualification is lineage, which is not a qualification Paul mentions.

Have any of your current or recent elders been installed for loyalty, generosity, or legacy reasons rather than genuine qualification? What effect has that had on the team's culture and function?

What would change in your elder selection culture if the congregation understood that declining a nomination is an act of integrity rather than a personal rejection?

What is the implicit message your current elder selection process sends about what the office requires? Is that the message you want to send?

CHAPTER TWO

Above Reproach

THE MASTER QUALIFICATION AND what it means in practice

Paul's list in 1 Timothy 3 begins with the phrase "above reproach," and everything that follows is a detailed description of what above reproach actually looks like. This is not one qualification among many. It is the summary qualification — the umbrella under which everything else falls.

Above reproach does not mean sinless. If it did, the qualification would disqualify every human being who has ever lived. It means something more specific and more achievable: a man against whom no legitimate accusation is currently standing. A man whose life, when honestly examined, does not provide grounds for a credible charge of moral or spiritual unfitness.

The word Paul uses — *anepileptos* — literally means "not able to be laid hold of." The image is of a man walking in such a way that there is nothing to grab onto. He is not perfect. But there is no obvious, open vulnerability in his character that

WHAT “ABOVE REPROACH” REQUIRES

THE POSITIVE CONTENT OF this qualification is significant. It requires a man whose reputation in the congregation is genuinely positive — not universally liked, but widely respected. It requires a man whose known patterns of behavior are consistent with what the gospel produces: honesty, generosity, self-control, kindness, patience. It requires a man who, when his life is honestly assessed, is found to be genuinely walking in the Spirit rather than merely performing Christianity for institutional purposes.

This assessment requires information. You cannot determine whether a man is above reproach from his church attendance, his giving record, and his performance on committees. You need to know how he treats his wife when they disagree. You need to know how he handles frustration at work. You need to know what his neighbors say about him. You need to know whether the man in the board meeting is the same man in the living room.

This is why the elder qualification process must involve more than a conversation with the candidate himself. It must involve the candidate's spouse. It should involve people who know him in contexts other than Sunday morning. It should involve honest conversation within the elder team about what members of the congregation know and observe. The assessment of “above reproach” requires a wide enough angle of view that genuine patterns can be assessed rather than merely impressions.

ONE OF THE MOST important distinctions in applying the above-reproach qualification is the distinction between past failure and present pattern. These are not the same thing, and treating them as if they are produces both false disqualifications and false qualifications.

Past failure that has been genuinely repented of, publicly owned where appropriate, and demonstrably changed over time does not disqualify a man from eldership. Paul himself was a persecutor of the church before he became its greatest missionary. Peter denied Christ before he became the rock of the early church. The gospel produces repentance and restoration, and the qualification “above reproach” does not require a man with no history. It requires a man who is not currently in reproach.

But present pattern — a pattern of behavior that is ongoing, unaddressed, or defended — is a different matter entirely. The man who continues to fly into rages at his family while maintaining a composed demeanor in elder meetings is not above reproach. He is below reproach in the most important contexts — the hidden ones. The man whose business practices are known in the community to be sharp or dishonest is not above reproach. The man who has had a pattern of inappropriate emotional intimacy with women in the congregation is not above reproach, even if each individual incident was ambiguous.

The assessment process must be equipped to ask: not whether this man has ever failed, but whether there are patterns in his current life that provide grounds for legitimate reproach. And it must be willing to receive honest answers to

WHEN THE REPROACH IS HIDDEN

THE MOST DIFFICULT APPLICATION of the above-reproach qualification involves the man whose failures are hidden from the congregation. The man whose wife knows things the elder team does not. The man whose anger is reserved for private contexts. The man whose financial patterns are visible only to those who have worked with him closely.

This is why the spouse conversation is so important in the evaluation process. A wise spouse who genuinely loves both her husband and her church will not lie to protect him from a qualification process. She may struggle with what to share and how to share it. But the question “Is there anything about your husband’s life that you believe would concern the elder team?” — asked with care, in the context of a genuine relationship, by someone the spouse trusts — is one of the most important questions in the entire assessment.

It is not a perfect safeguard. But it is a significant one. And the elder team that treats this conversation as optional is accepting a level of informational blindness that the above-reproach qualification cannot be meaningfully applied within.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

How does your current elder evaluation process assess the hidden dimensions of a candidate’s life? Does it rely primarily on the candidate’s own self-presentation?

Do you have examples of men in your church’s history who were installed as elders with hidden patterns that later became visible problems? What would have surfaced those patterns earlier?

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Is your elder team prepared to decline a candidate whose past failure, though genuinely repented of, has left a level of ongoing question in the congregation that would compromise his ability to lead?

CHAPTER THREE

Husband of One Wife, Managing His Household

CHARACTER AT HOME AS the proving ground of character in the church

The qualification most likely to generate uncomfortable conversation in an elder evaluation is also the qualification most likely to reveal the most important truths about the candidate.

Paul devotes more attention to the elder's family than to any other single area of qualification. He is the husband of one wife. He manages his household well. His children are submissive and respectable. This is not incidental emphasis. Paul knows something that modern church governance culture tends to obscure: the home is the proving ground of character. What a man is at home is what a man is. And an elder's leadership of the church will ultimately reflect the quality of his leadership of his household.

HUSBAND OF ONE WIFE: WHAT THE

FEW PHRASES IN THE Pastoral Epistles have generated more scholarly discussion and practical confusion than “husband of one wife.” The Greek literally says “one-woman man” (*mias gunaikos andra*), and the debate about its application has continued for centuries.

Some interpret it primarily as a prohibition of polygamy — the elder may have only one wife simultaneously. In a culture where polygamy was practiced, this would have been a meaningful requirement. But it probably means more than this.

Others interpret it as a prohibition of divorce and remarriage — the elder may not have been divorced and remarried. This interpretation has significant support in the historical context and in the overall emphasis of the text on marital fidelity. But its rigorous application creates genuine pastoral difficulty in cases where divorce was clearly the other spouse’s fault or where genuine repentance and restoration have occurred.

The most contextually sensitive interpretation understands the phrase as a qualitative statement about the elder’s marital character: he is a man devoted to his wife. He is not a man with a wandering eye. He is not a man who flirts with other women. He is not a man who nourishes inappropriate emotional intimacy with women outside his marriage. He is — in the full biblical sense of the word — a one-woman man.

This interpretation neither ignores the possible implications for divorce and remarriage nor makes an absolute rule that admits no pastoral nuance. It focuses on what Paul seems primarily to be after: not the marital history

The Divorce and Remarriage Question

The practical question of whether a divorced-and-remarried man may serve as an elder is one that different Reformed and evangelical traditions have answered differently, and this book is not the place to adjudicate the exegetical debate. What can be said with confidence is this: the marital history of an elder candidate is relevant to the assessment, and it must be assessed honestly rather than ignored.

Relevant questions include: What were the circumstances of the divorce? Has genuine repentance occurred where sin was involved? How much time has passed, and has the pattern of the man's life demonstrated lasting change? What is the quality of his current marriage? Does the community — both inside and outside the church — see his current marital relationship as an example worth following?

These are not easy questions. But they are the right questions. And they should be asked without either the reflexive disqualification that refuses to consider context or the reflexive accommodation that avoids the question entirely to spare an awkward conversation.

MANAGING HIS HOUSEHOLD WELL

THE HOUSEHOLD MANAGEMENT QUALIFICATION in 1 Timothy 3:4–5 is one of the most practically instructive in the entire list. “He must manage his own household well, with all dignity keeping his children submissive, for if someone does not know how to manage his own household, how will he care for God's church?”

Paul's logic is explicit. The household is the training

The word translated “manage” (proistemi) means to lead, to superintend, to give direction and care. It is the same word used in 1 Thessalonians 5:12 for the leaders of the church: “respect those who labor among you and are over you (proistamenous) in the Lord.” The elder’s leadership of his household is the same kind of leadership the church requires of its elders. They are not different skills. They are the same skill applied in a different context.

What does household leadership look like when it is genuinely healthy? It looks like a man who is present — not merely physically in the home but emotionally and spiritually engaged with his family. A man whose wife feels genuinely known and genuinely supported. A man whose children know they are loved unconditionally and that there are boundaries they are expected to stay within. A man whose home is characterized by both warmth and order, both grace and accountability.

This is not a demanding standard in the sense of requiring a perfect family. Every family has tension, struggle, and difficulty. The qualification is not that the elder’s family is problem-free. It is that he is managing it — that he is engaged, responsible, and producing a broadly healthy household through consistent, loving leadership.

THE CHILDREN QUESTION

elder's children in both 1 Timothy 3:4 and Titus 1:6 is the qualification that generates the most pastoral anxiety in elder evaluation processes. The Titus version is especially pointed: "children who are believers and not open to the charge of debauchery or insubordination."

Two clarifications are important before this qualification can be applied wisely. First, the context of both passages suggests primarily children who are still in the home and under the elder's direct care — not adult children who have made their own decisions. The question is whether the elder is currently parenting well, not whether every child he has ever raised has remained in the faith into adulthood.

Second, the Titus version's reference to "believing children" is understood by many commentators to refer primarily to children who are faithful and trustworthy — the word *pistos* carries both senses in Greek — rather than requiring that all of an elder's children have made public professions of faith at the age of evaluation.

That said, the spiritual trajectory of an elder's children is not irrelevant. If the children of an elder are known in the congregation primarily for their contempt for the faith their father professes, this creates a genuine credibility question about the quality of his household leadership — not as an automatic disqualifier, but as a matter that requires honest pastoral conversation.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What does your elder evaluation process actually learn about how a candidate leads his household? Does it rely primarily on what the candidate says about himself, or on what his wife and others observe?

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What does the quality of your current elders' marriages say to the congregation about what a Christian marriage looks like? Are their marriages genuinely exemplary?

Are there any current or candidate elders whose children's behavior raises legitimate questions about their household leadership? Has anyone named it directly?

CHAPTER FOUR

Self-Controlled, Sober-Minded, Respectable

THE INNER LIFE QUALIFICATIONS that reveal the man underneath the title

The qualifications that follow the household qualifications in 1 Timothy 3 move inward. Paul describes the elder's inner life, his emotional and psychological character, his relationship to his own appetites and impulses. Sober-minded. Self-controlled. Respectable. Not a drunkard. Not violent but gentle. Not quarrelsome.

These qualifications are harder to assess than institutional performance and easier to fake than household leadership. A man can be self-controlled in public settings while being entirely controlled by his impulses in private. A man can be gentle in board meetings while being volatile in traffic. A man can present as sober-minded while privately catastrophizing every difficulty and making decisions from a place of anxiety rather than faith.

The inner life qualifications require the most honest

SOBER-MINDED: THE QUALIFICATION OF CLEAR THINKING

THE GREEK WORD SOPHRONA, typically translated “sober-minded” or “self-controlled,” carries a meaning that is richer than its common English equivalents suggest. It describes a mind that is balanced, clear, and ordered — not dominated by emotional reactivity, not prone to catastrophic thinking, not easily swept into enthusiasm or panic.

In an age of constant information, constant controversy, and constant crisis, sober-mindedness is an increasingly rare and increasingly precious quality. The elder who is sober-minded processes difficulty without dramatizing it. He evaluates options without being paralyzed by anxiety. He holds conviction without being swept into reactivity. He provides the congregation with stable leadership in unstable times precisely because his own thinking is not destabilized by external pressures.

The opposite of sober-mindedness is not necessarily dramatic mental illness. It is the more ordinary patterns of emotional reactivity that many people develop without ever recognizing them as problematic: the tendency to read every setback as catastrophe, the tendency to let strong feelings override clear thinking, the tendency to change positions under social pressure rather than under the weight of evidence and argument.

These patterns do real damage in an elder who holds genuine authority over a congregation. The sober-minded

SELF-CONTROL: THE FOUNDATION OF ALL THE OTHER QUALIFICATIONS

SELF-CONTROL (ENKRATEIA) IS, IN a real sense, the foundation of all the other character qualifications. The man who is not self-controlled will not remain above reproach for long. The man without self-control will not maintain the marital fidelity that the one-woman-man qualification requires. The man without self-control will not sustain the household management that Paul describes. He will not be gentle, because his impulses will override his gentleness when under pressure. He will not be free from the love of money, because his appetites will override his integrity when the financial temptation is sufficiently attractive.

Self-control is the capacity to act in accordance with one's own convictions rather than in accordance with one's immediate impulses, desires, or emotional states. It is not the suppression of emotion or the denial of desire. It is the governance of emotion and desire by something deeper — by conviction, by love for God, by commitment to others, by the slow formation of a character that has been genuinely shaped by the Holy Spirit over time.

How do you assess self-control in an elder candidate? You watch patterns over time. You listen to how the candidate speaks about those who have frustrated him. You observe how he responds when he is corrected or challenged. You ask his wife how he handles disagreements at home. You ask those who work with him professionally whether he

NOT A DRUNKARD: THE PRINCIPLE BEHIND THE SPECIFIC

THE QUALIFICATION THAT THE elder be “not a drunkard” (or in Titus, “not addicted to much wine”) is specific in its language and broader in its application. In the ancient Mediterranean world, wine was ubiquitous, and the temptation to excess was real. Paul’s prohibition addresses a specific cultural context.

But the principle behind the specific prohibition is broader: the elder must not be governed by any physical appetite. The man who is controlled by alcohol, or by food, or by pornography, or by any other substance or behavior that has developed into a compulsive pattern — is disqualified not merely because of the specific behavior but because of what that behavior reveals about his self-control and his inner life.

This is one of the qualifications most likely to be obscured from a formal evaluation process, because addictive and compulsive behaviors are often carefully managed in public settings and concealed from institutional scrutiny. The confidential spouse conversation is again one of the most important tools available for surfacing patterns that the candidate himself would not volunteer.

NOT VIOLENT, GENTLE, NOT QUARRELSOME

PAUL’S TRIPLE DESCRIPTION OF the elder’s relational

The violent man — not necessarily physically violent, but emotionally forceful, given to intimidation, quick to escalate — will create a culture of fear wherever he leads. The quarrelsome man — the man who never backs down, who cannot distinguish between essential convictions and personal preferences, who treats every disagreement as a battle to be won — will create a culture of exhaustion wherever he leads. Neither is compatible with the patient, sacrificial, long-suffering character that genuine shepherding requires.

Gentleness (*epieikeia*) is one of the most theologically rich words in the New Testament. It describes a quality of flexibility and magnanimity that does not insist on its rights, that bends where bending is appropriate without breaking where conviction requires firmness. Jesus used it of himself in Matthew 11:29: “I am gentle and lowly in heart.” It is a quality that holds authority and accessibility together in a way that makes the powerful person approachable and the vulnerable person safe.

The elder who is genuinely gentle is one of the greatest gifts a congregation can receive. He is safe to bring your struggles to. He is safe to disagree with. He holds his authority lightly enough that people are not afraid of him, and firmly enough that the congregation is genuinely protected by his leadership.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

How do you assess self-control and sober-mindedness in candidates without relying primarily on their institutional performance?

Are there candidates or current elders whose patterns of anger, argumentativeness, or appetite-driven behavior raise concerns under these qualifications? Has that been named directly?

What would it look like to apply the “not violent, gentle, not quarrelsome” standards as evaluation criteria rather than mere aspirational descriptions?

CHAPTER FIVE

Able to Teach, Not a Lover of Money, Not a Recent Convert

THE REMAINING QUALIFICATIONS AND what they require

The final cluster of qualifications in 1 Timothy 3 addresses the elder's doctrinal capacity, his financial integrity, and the question of his maturity in the faith. Each of these qualifications is practically significant, and each is more commonly neglected in elder evaluation processes than the household and character qualifications that precede them.

ABLE TO TEACH: MORE THAN A MINIMUM THRESHOLD

WE HAVE ALREADY TREATED the teaching qualification in detail in Chapter Three of Book One. But it is worth revisiting in the context of this evaluation chapter, because “able to teach” is the qualification most

The minimum threshold for “able to teach” is not whether a man can speak coherently about biblical topics. It is whether he has a sufficiently stable, clear, and confident grasp of Scripture and theology that he can “give instruction in sound doctrine and also rebuke those who contradict it” (Titus 1:9).

This requires that the candidate actually know the Bible. Not academically — he does not need to have attended seminary. But substantively. He should be a man who reads Scripture regularly and thoughtfully, who has wrestled with its content over years rather than merely skimming it, and who has developed opinions about what it says that are grounded in the text rather than in cultural assumptions or personal preference.

A meaningful assessment of this qualification involves asking the candidate to walk through a doctrinal question — how would he explain the gospel? What does he believe about the authority of Scripture? How does he understand baptism, the Lord’s Supper, the nature of salvation? Not to test him against a precise confessional standard, but to evaluate whether his theological thinking is clear, stable, and genuinely grounded.

It also involves asking: what does he do when he encounters teaching he suspects is wrong? Does he engage it, or does he defer it? Does he have the courage and the clarity to say “That is not what the Bible teaches” and explain why? The rebuke dimension of the teaching qualification requires not just doctrinal knowledge but doctrinal courage.

NOT A LOVER OF MONEY

appears

in both 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1, which suggests that Paul considers it especially important for church leadership. In 1 Timothy 3:3 it is “not a lover of money” (aphilargyron). In Titus 1:7 it is “not greedy for gain” (me aischrokerdes — literally, not pursuing shameful gain).

The reason for this emphasis is not difficult to identify. The elder has oversight of institutional resources. He is privy to information about the financial circumstances of congregation members that could be exploited. He wields influence that could be leveraged for personal gain in ways that are difficult to detect and even more difficult to address after the fact.

But the qualification runs deeper than the corruption risks it addresses. An elder who is oriented toward financial gain — who is motivated primarily by accumulation and comfort, who makes decisions (including ministry decisions) based primarily on their financial implications for himself — is demonstrating that his primary allegiance is not to the Chief Shepherd or the flock. His heart is oriented toward mammon rather than toward God. And Jesus was quite clear that these two orientations cannot coexist.

How do you assess this? You ask about it directly. How does the candidate think about money? What does his giving look like relative to his income? How does he make financial decisions — is the first question about cost, or is it about mission and stewardship? What do those who have worked with him professionally observe about his financial ethics? What does his spouse say about how they navigate financial decisions together?

NOT A RECENT CONVERT

PAUL'S PROHIBITION IN 1 Timothy 3:6 against installing recent converts as elders is among the most neglected in contemporary practice. “He must not be a recent convert, or he may become puffed up with conceit and fall into the condemnation of the devil.”

The word translated “recent convert” is *neophytos* — newly planted. And the danger Paul identifies is specific: pride. The spiritual gifts and natural leadership gifts that often make a recent convert impressive and exciting are precisely the gifts that can be distorted by premature authority into something destructive.

The mature Christian understands, through years of experience, that his gifts are not his own, that leadership is a form of service, and that the authority he exercises is borrowed from the Chief Shepherd rather than owned. The recent convert — however gifted — has not yet learned these things at the experiential level. He knows them as propositions. He has not yet had them tested and refined by the actual experience of failure, correction, and suffering in the Christian life.

How long is long enough? Paul does not specify, and the answer will vary with the individual. The question to ask is not primarily “How many years has he been a Christian?” but

What you are looking for is the humility that comes from experience — the self-knowledge that only comes from having failed and been restored, from having been wrong and admitted it, from having been humbled by the actual experience of trying to live the Christian life over time. That quality cannot be rushed, and it cannot be substituted for by giftedness or enthusiasm, however impressive.

WELL THOUGHT OF BY OUTSIDERS

THE FINAL QUALIFICATION IN 1 Timothy 3:7 addresses the elder's reputation outside the church: "Moreover, he must be well thought of by outsiders, so that he may not fall into disgrace, into a snare of the devil."

This qualification is uniquely important because it requires information that the church itself cannot gather from within its own community. The elder's outside reputation is held by people who are not in the room when the elder is evaluated — his neighbors, his colleagues, his business partners, his customers, the people who interact with him in the ordinary contexts of daily life.

A meaningful evaluation process will make some attempt to assess this dimension of the candidate's reputation. Not through a formal survey, but through honest conversation with people who know the candidate outside the church context. What do his neighbors observe? What do his

The reason Paul gives for this qualification is significant: “so that he may not fall into disgrace, into a snare of the devil.” The elder whose outside reputation is compromised is vulnerable — to exposure, to accusation, to the kind of scandal that damages not just his own ministry but the witness of the entire congregation. Protecting the church from this vulnerability is not paranoia. It is wisdom.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Does your elder evaluation process actually assess the teaching qualification, or does it assume it? When did you last ask a candidate to walk through a doctrinal question in depth?

How do you assess a candidate’s relationship with money? Does the question even get asked, or is financial integrity assumed unless there is obvious evidence of misconduct?

Are there any candidates or current elders who were installed before they were sufficiently mature in the faith? What patterns in their leadership reflect that premature installation?

What would it take to gather meaningful information about a candidate’s reputation outside the church? Who would you need to talk to?

CHAPTER SIX

Designing a Meaningful Evaluation Process

TAKING THE QUALIFICATIONS FROM text to practice

The qualifications mean nothing if they are not meaningfully assessed. A church that knows 1 Timothy 3 by heart but does not actually apply it to its elder candidates has exchanged the appearance of biblical seriousness for the reality of institutional business-as-usual. The whole point of this book has been to move from the text to the practice — and this chapter is where that movement happens.

What follows is a framework for an elder evaluation process that is both biblically grounded and practically executable. It is not a formula. Every church will need to adapt it to its own polity, culture, and history. But it is a substantive model that takes the qualifications seriously without becoming an interrogation.

THE FIVE COMPONENTS OF A MEANINGFUL EVALUATION

for elder candidates has five components: self-assessment, elder team review, spouse conversation, congregational input, and doctrinal assessment. Each addresses a different dimension of the candidate's fitness for the office, and none of them can be safely skipped.

Component 1: The Self-Assessment

The self-assessment is the candidate's own engagement with the qualifications. It is not primarily a test — it is an act of self-knowledge. The candidate should spend meaningful time with 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1, asking himself honestly: where do I clearly meet this standard? Where am I uncertain? Where do I know I fall short?

The self-assessment serves two purposes. First, it surfaces areas of honest concern that the candidate may not otherwise volunteer, and those concerns deserve to be heard and engaged before a decision is made. Second, it reveals how the candidate relates to honest self-examination — whether he is capable of genuine self-knowledge or whether he is primarily managing impressions. A man who has no honest concerns about his own qualification is either remarkably mature or remarkably unaware. Either answer is informative.

A written self-assessment tool — one that walks the candidate through each qualification with specific questions — is more effective than a general invitation to reflect. It ensures that every qualification is considered rather than only the ones the candidate finds comfortable.

Component 2: The Elder Team Review

The existing elder team's assessment of the candidate is the core of the process. These are the men who will serve alongside him, who know the congregation well enough to

The elder team review should be a genuine conversation rather than a vote. It should include specific discussion of each qualification, specific examples from the candidate's life in the congregation, and honest space for concerns to be raised without shame or political pressure. The goal is not consensus at any cost — it is honest discernment.

A specific question the elder team should ask about each qualification: “Do we have positive evidence that this man meets this standard, or are we simply assuming he does?” The absence of negative evidence is not the same as the presence of positive evidence. The evaluation process should actively seek positive evidence of each qualification, not merely confirm that no disqualifying information is currently known.

Component 3: The Spouse Conversation

We have already noted the importance of the spouse conversation in assessing the household and character qualifications. Here we simply emphasize that it must happen and that it must be a genuine conversation rather than a perfunctory interview.

The conversation should be conducted by someone the spouse knows and trusts — ideally a pastor or an elder's wife who has a genuine relationship with her. It should be private. And it should make explicitly clear that the spouse's honest input is valued and that she will not be blamed for anything she shares.

Key questions: How does your husband lead in the home? How does he handle conflict between the two of you? How

The spouse who genuinely loves her husband will want this process to be taken seriously. Because she knows better than anyone what his candidacy for an office of significant spiritual responsibility actually means, and what it requires.

Component 4: Congregational Input

The congregation's knowledge of the candidate is an important input that the formal evaluation process often fails to gather. Members of the congregation have observed the candidate in contexts the elder team may not have — in small groups, in service roles, in moments of conflict or difficulty, in the informal interactions of community life.

A brief, confidential process for gathering congregational input — not a vote, but an invitation to share information — communicates that the church takes the qualifications seriously and that the congregation's knowledge of the candidate is valued. It also surfaces concerns that might otherwise remain below the surface until they become problems after installation.

Component 5: The Doctrinal Assessment

The doctrinal assessment — a direct conversation about theology, Scripture, and doctrinal conviction — is the most commonly skipped component of elder evaluation. It feels awkward. It feels like a test. It risks embarrassing a candidate in front of people who know him.

Do it anyway.

A structured doctrinal conversation — in a private setting, with a posture of curiosity rather than examination — is the

The candidate who is genuinely theologically capable will welcome this conversation. The candidate who is theologically thin will struggle with it. Either outcome is valuable information.

COMMUNICATING THE RESULTS

HOW THE RESULTS OF the evaluation are communicated matters almost as much as the evaluation itself.

When the result is affirmation, the installation should be a significant occasion — not a brief announcement from the pulpit, but a meaningful service that includes a charge from Scripture, the laying on of hands, prayer from the congregation, and a clear articulation of what the congregation is affirming and what they are being called to support. The weight of the office should be felt in the service.

When the result is a “not yet,” the communication to the candidate should be personal, honest, caring, and specific. He deserves to know what concerns led to the decision, and he deserves to hear them from someone who has a genuine relationship with him. A “not yet” that is accompanied by a clear development plan — specific areas of growth to pursue, a time frame for reconsideration, ongoing support from the elder team — is an act of pastoral care. A “not yet” without that support is simply a rejection.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Which of the five evaluation components does your current process actually include? Which are missing, and what would it take to add them?

What would you do if the spouse conversation surfaced significant concerns about a popular candidate? Do you have the relational and institutional capital to act on what you learn?

How has your church historically communicated “not yet” or “no” decisions to candidates? Has the communication been honest, caring, and specific enough to be genuinely helpful?

What would a meaningful, appropriately weighty elder installation service look like in your specific context? When did you last conduct one?

Conclusion: The Standard Is an Act of Love

THERE IS A TENDENCY, when reading a book like this, to feel that it is primarily a book about exclusion. About all the reasons why the men you were thinking about nominating might not actually be qualified. About all the standards that might not be met.

That is not the spirit in which it was written.

The elder qualification standard is an act of love. It is love for the men who hold the office — because it calls them to a level of character development that will shape them, refine them, and make them more genuinely useful to God and to others over time. It is love for the congregations they will serve — because it ensures that the men with authority over the spiritual welfare of those congregations are genuinely equipped to exercise that authority well. And it is love for the men who are not yet qualified — because it tells them the

The church that holds the standard high is not being cruel. It is being faithful. It is saying to the congregation: the men who will keep watch over your souls are men who have demonstrated, in their actual lives, that the gospel has genuinely transformed them. That is worth something. That is worth protecting. That is worth the uncomfortable conversations and the occasional disappointed nominations.

The chief qualification for elder ministry is not competency. It is character. And character is not given by a title. It is formed by a life.

Call men to the life. Hold the title for those who are living it. And watch the Chief Shepherd work through the men who are truly qualified to shepherd in his name.

And when the chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the unfading crown of glory. — 1 Peter 5:4